

The Washington Post

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Mostly cloudy 52/47 • Tomorrow: Afternoon shower 56/52 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 20, 2025 • \$4

Noem and panel split on future of FEMA

Council suggests raising the agency's autonomy rather than shrinking it

BY BRIANNA SACKS
AND ISAAC ARNSDORF

A panel appointed by President Donald Trump to review whether to eliminate the Federal Emergency Management Agency has instead concluded in a report that the agency should be more powerful and autonomous. Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem, however, wants to take FEMA in a different direction.

The wrangling over the FEMA review council's long-awaited report, which has been in the works for nearly 10 months, will help determine the fate of one of Trump's controversial efforts to reshape the government and its ability to respond to disasters such as floods, fires and hurricanes.

Noem, as the council co-chair, is responsible for finalizing the report and sending it to Trump for review. Her draft, which is not finished, recommends keeping FEMA within the Department of Homeland Security and largely removing FEMA from its direct role in disaster relief, instead turning it into more of a grant-making operation, according to five people familiar with the situation who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the private deliberations. The council's earlier draft did not recommend those changes, but rather that FEMA gets elevated to a Cabinet-level office.

Noem's office also wants to reduce the federal government's share of disaster-related costs to 50 percent, with states having to fund the other 50 percent with cash, which some council members staunchly opposed, according to a person familiar with the situation. Under FEMA guidelines, the federal government covers about 75 percent of costs, and in extreme cases it will front nearly 100 percent for a period of

SEE FEMA ON A2

Congresswoman charged: DOJ alleges she stole FEMA funds. **A2**



PHOTOS BY HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

West Bank attacks surge unchecked

BY HEIDI LEVINE,
LOUISA LOVELUCK
AND LIOR SOROKA

JABA, WEST BANK — Israeli political and military leaders are scrambling to contain a recent wave of settler attacks across the West Bank, warning against further violence targeting Palestinian communities as vigilantes have rampaged through villages, beating local residents, torching a mosque, and assaulting and injuring Israeli security forces who helped demolish an illegal outpost this week near the flash point city of Hebron.

The attacks, carried out by roving gangs of masked men and boys, have underscored the extent to which the Israeli government has allowed Jewish settlers to operate with impunity in the occupied territory. They have also exposed a deep rift between the most radical Israeli settlers, who believe they have a divine right to the land, and parts of the traditional security establishment, which sees the violence as destabilizing and undermining the state.

Israeli figures warn that state has 'lost control' as violence rises against Palestinian residents



TOP: Ahmad Salman, 32, the imam of the Haja Hamida Mosque, stands in a destroyed room last Thursday after an overnight attack by Jewish settlers in the Palestinian village of Deir Istiya in the West Bank. **ABOVE:** Salman holds burned pages of a ruined Quran.

In recent days, senior Israeli officials, including Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, President Isaac Herzog and Defense Minister Israel Katz, have condemned what they described as violent incidents perpetrated by a small group of extremists. Herzog called the violence "shocking and serious" and said it "crosses a red line." And Katz, who last year ended administrative detention for Jewish settlers suspected of attacks, pledged more money and resources Monday for a Defense Ministry initiative he said seeks to reduce the attacks through dialogue.

But current and former members of Israel's political and security elite have also urgently raised the alarm — and instead blamed the government for enacting policies they said either encouraged settler violence or allowed it to flourish.

"Israel is reaping what it sowed: the entire racist policy of pushing and harming the Palestinians,"

SEE WEST BANK ON A12

In Gaza: Israeli strikes kill at least 25 people despite ceasefire. **A11**

THE DEADLIEST ROADS IN AMERICA

Number of pedestrians killed by vehicles has surged amid neglect and lack of investment by transportation authorities, an analysis of federal data and other public records shows

BY IAN DUNCAN,
EMMANUEL MARTINEZ
AND DYLAN MORIARTY

MEMPHIS — After his brother was fatally struck by a vehicle while crossing the seven lanes of Jackson Avenue, Keith Smith found a single clue: a chunk of broken headlight that he suspected came from a utility truck.

The impact separated David Booker's skull from the bones in his neck, left his brain bleeding, tore a lung and caused internal injuries, according to an autopsy report. Doctors declared him brain-dead a day later. With little sign of a police investigation, Smith fruitlessly sought surveillance video from a nearby McDonald's. He stood vigil on Jackson Avenue for days, hoping to spot a heavy Ford truck with a shattered headlight — until, Smith said, people started looking at him as if he was crazy.

The case remains listed as an unsolved hit-and-run — written off, in Smith's view, as just another



ILLUSTRATION BY TYLER REMMEL AND DYLAN MORIARTY/WASHINGTON POST; GOOGLE EARTH

er pedestrian death in a rough part of town.

"Oh, well, another person got hit, but, you know, it's common," Smith said. "It's like it's part of life right there."

The stretch of Jackson Avenue is among the deadliest roads in Memphis, itself the nation's most dangerous metro area for pedestrians. But it's not just Jackson Avenue, and it's not just Memphis.

Booker's death in September 2022 fit an escalating pattern on America's roads. Between 2010 and 2023, yearly deaths caused by cars and trucks striking pedestrians rose 70 percent, an examination of federal data and other public records by The Washington Post shows.

City by city across the United States, the surge — from 4,302 deaths in 2010 to 7,314 in 2023 — largely occurred on roads with a few things in common. The deaths were concentrated on multilane roads, with the largest

SEE ROADS ON A8

Makeover of 'left-wing' Fla. school is expensive

After DeSantis overhaul, costs at New College are highest in state system

BY LORI ROZSA

Nearly three years ago, as Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis championed his culture war policies during the run-up to a bid for the White House, he vowed to overhaul a small, quirky liberal arts college in Sarasota that was part of the state education system.

New College of Florida was "more into DEI, CRT, the gender ideology," the Republican governor said, using abbreviations for diversity, equity and inclusion and for critical race theory. He added: "We're going to be able to offer some reforms."

DeSantis has largely succeeded in transforming what was one of the most liberal institutions in the state into a school that is now hailed by conservatives across the country. He handpicked a

new president and appointed a board of trustees who fired and denied tenure to veteran professors. The school closed its gender studies center. It added sports teams and turned classrooms in a historic campus building into donor-friendly spaces with cigar smoking allowed on the balcony overlooking Sarasota Bay.

Now the bill for that effort has arrived, and it shows a remarkably high price. According to a report released this month by the Florida Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE), the cost to produce a degree at New College is \$494,715 — the highest among public colleges in Florida and more than three times the \$150,729 cost at the state's flagship school, the University of Florida.

Operating expenses at New College are \$83,207 per student, compared with \$45,765 at UF. New College also has the largest number of administrators per student, or 33.3 per 100, compared with 26.9 at UF, a school with nearly 62,000 students.

SEE COLLEGE ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Epstein case President Donald Trump said he signed a bill directing the Justice Department to release the files from its investigation. **A7**

Growing pains The Cedar Hill hospital in Southeast Washington has not yet delivered services key to keeping it financially afloat, but officials say that could soon change. **B13**

THE NATION
House members alleged a patient showed signs of life during organ harvesting. **A2**
An admission from the Justice Department upended the case against James B. Comey. **A3**

THE WORLD
Haiti witnessed a rare outburst of public joy after qualifying for the men's World Cup. **A10**
China is responding harshly to remarks about Taiwan by Japan's new leader. **A11**

THE ECONOMY
The Federal Reserve is more divided than it has been in years as it grapples with inflation, a weakening job market and pressure from the White House. **A14**
The average cost of a Thanksgiving dinner has fallen this year, an agriculture group said. **A14**

STYLE
A time-travel play by Tom Hanks is a sci-fi rom-com gone awry, a reviewer warns. **B1**
SPORTS
U-Md. basketball standout Yarden Garzon, an Israeli native, transferred to College Park to find her community. It's worked. **B7**

THE REGION
The head of a Virginia homeless shelter pleaded guilty to embezzling funds to pay for travel, antiques and more. **B13**

LOCAL LIVING
Hosting guests for the holidays? Check out these tips from experts on entertaining and home-keeping.

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